

A Field Guide for the AI Gold Rush

Part 5 and Epilogue

How councils, public services and change teams can use AI without breathing the mercury and calling it progress.

Marty McFry

A Field Guide for the AI Gold Rush

Part 5 and Epilogue

By this point in the series, the mine is no longer a metaphor behaving itself.

AI is useful, expensive, industrial and increasingly unavoidable. That combination should make us curious, not dazzled. This guide is for councils, public services, universities, charities, small businesses, change teams, procurement teams and anyone else who will not build frontier models, chips or data centres, but will still be told that AI is now unavoidable.

Too close to ignore it. Too small to shape it. Too accountable to be careless.

Not a strategy. We have enough strategies. Most of them are laminated anxieties with a contents page. A field guide is different. It is what you carry when the terrain is uncertain, the map is incomplete and the locals disagree about whether the animal in front of you is dangerous, useful or merely expensive.

Series trail	Where this guide fits
AI Is a Black Hole With a Bubble at the Edge	Capital, circularity, bubbles and the pull of the AI black hole.
When the Mine Builds Its Own Shovels	Jalapeno, Nvidia, CUDA, kernels and the machinery of inference.
The Mine Needs a Grid	Data centres, power, planning, water and physical infrastructure.
Near the Event Horizon	Procurement, dependency, public accountability and governance.

The Ten Rules

Use these as prompts in discovery, procurement, governance boards, AI pilot reviews and service redesign sessions.

1

Do not confuse usefulness with transformation

AI can draft, summarise, classify, compare, translate, search and help people get started. That matters in stretched organisations. But transformation means the work changes, the evidence improves, capacity is released deliberately and people understand the new way of working after the excitement leaves the room.

Field question: What work has actually changed?

Field question: Where has capacity been released?

Field question: What has become safer, clearer or faster?

2

Follow the authority

Forget the usual question, where is AI being used? Ask where authority is moving. If AI frames the issue, ranks options or summarises away context before a human sees the material, the centre of gravity has shifted even if the form still says human in the loop.

Field question: What does the human see first?

Field question: What is hidden or ranked?

Field question: Where might approval become decorative?

3

Ask whether AI is solving the problem or flattering it

Many organisations do not have an AI problem. They have a process problem, data problem, governance problem or an everyone-knows-this-is-broken-but-nobody-owns-it problem. AI can help. It can also make failure look better dressed.

Field question: What is the underlying service problem?

Field question: Would this still be sensible without AI?

Field question: Are we improving the work or the presentation of the work?

4

Demand evidence before scale

Not vibes. Evidence. If a tool saves time, whose time? How much? Measured against what? What happened to the released capacity? Did risk fall, quality improve or residents receive a better service?

Field question: What is the baseline?

Field question: What hidden costs have we counted?

Field question: Who checks whether benefits are real?

5

Treat supplier AI as a dependency, not a feature

A supplier says their product includes AI-powered insight. Fine. Ask what that means. Which model? Hosted where? Using what data? Can it be disabled? Can outputs be audited? What happens when the price changes?

Field question: Can we switch it off?

Field question: Can we leave?

Field question: What dependency are we creating?

6

Protect the human disciplines

AI will be most dangerous where organisations use it to avoid thinking. Better reports, faster summaries and polished dashboards are not the same as judgement, memory, grip or learning.

Field question: Who understands the argument?

Field question: Who knows what was left out?

Field question: Are people becoming more capable or merely more dependent?

7

Know what must remain human

Some things can be assisted by AI, but must not be surrendered to it: rights, entitlements, enforcement, safeguarding, vulnerability, democratic accountability, complaints and statutory judgement. The line is not anti-AI. It is legitimacy.

Field question: Where does support end and authority begin?

Field question: What decisions affect power over residents?

Field question: What must always have accountable human judgement?

8

Keep an exit route

Before adopting an AI tool at scale, ask how you would leave it. If the answer is we will work that out later, you are building dependency with a ribbon on it.

Field question: Can we export the data?

Field question: Can another supplier take over?

Field question: Can the workflow continue without the AI feature?

9

Beware inevitability

The market loves inevitability. Everyone is doing it. Adopt now or be left behind. Sometimes true. Often theatre. Public bodies do not get to outsource judgement to inevitability.

Field question: Who benefits from urgency?

Field question: What are we not doing because we are doing this?

Field question: Who owns the mine?

10

Stay close to the work

AI strategy written too far from real work becomes fantasy. The useful knowledge sits with people who know where forms confuse residents, data fails, policy is ambiguous and the official process parted company with the actual process.

Field question: Who knows where the machinery jams?

Field question: Have we watched the work?

Field question: Are we optimising the real process or the imagined one?

Procurement Questions That Should Not Be Optional

Use this as a supplier conversation guide. If the answers are vague, the risk has not disappeared. It has moved into the contract.

Area	Ask this	Why it matters
Model	Which model is used, who provides it and how often can it change?	A quiet model change can alter behaviour, quality and assurance assumptions.
Data	Where is data processed, retained and logged?	Data protection, auditability and public trust live here.
Control	Can AI features be disabled or configured by use case?	A feature you cannot govern is a dependency.
Evidence	How are outputs tested, measured and monitored?	Claims of accuracy or productivity need a baseline.
Human role	Where is human review required and how is it recorded?	Human in the loop is weak if the loop is decorative.
Exit	Can we export data, prompts, knowledge bases and configurations?	Leaving later should not require rebuilding the service from memory.
Cost	What happens to pricing at scale or if usage grows sharply?	Cheap pilots can become expensive operating models.
Failure	What happens if the AI component is withdrawn, degraded or unavailable?	Resilience is not a slide. It is a tested fallback.

Red Flags

- The supplier cannot say where AI is used.
- Productivity benefits are asserted without a baseline.
- The pilot saves visible time but creates hidden checking work.
- Staff are expected to approve outputs they cannot properly interrogate.
- The AI feature cannot be switched off without breaking the workflow.
- No one can explain how residents, service users or vulnerable people could be affected.

AI Pilot One-Page Test

Before scaling a pilot, try to answer this on one page. If it needs a novel to explain, the work may not yet be understood.

Question	Working answer
What work are we trying to improve?	
What is the current baseline for time, quality, risk or resident experience?	
What will AI do, and what will it never do?	
Who remains accountable for the output?	
What evidence would justify scaling?	
What hidden costs must be counted?	
What would cause us to stop?	

The Mug Test

Will AI help this, or merely make it fail faster?

That question is deliberately awkward. It forces the conversation back to the work, the process, the dependency and the people affected by the decision.

Closing Note

This is why the gold-rush metaphor matters all the way to the end.

My grandfather worked near Charters Towers in Queensland during the 1880s gold rush. He had travelled from Wartemburg and became an amalgamator, part of the practical machinery of extraction. The job sat somewhere between hope and harm. Crushed ore. Mercury. Skill. Risk. The dream of gold and the bodily reality of getting it out of the rock.

A gold rush is never just gold. It is machinery, debt, labour, damage, hope, migration, speculation and the people close enough to the process to breathe in the cost.

The AI rush has its own version of all that.

The capital is circling. The mines are building shovels. The grid is being dragged into the story. Organisations are approaching the event horizon through procurement, convenience and dependency.

So the field guide is not complicated.

Do not sneer at the gold. Do not worship the machinery. Do not breathe the mercury and call it progress.

Use AI where it helps. Govern it where it matters. Measure it before scaling. Keep authority visible. Protect human judgement. Understand the dependency. Stay close to the work.

And when someone says the future is inevitable, ask them who owns the mine.

Related essays

AI Is a Black Hole With a Bubble at the Edge

When the Mine Builds Its Own Shovels

We Thought We Were Building Services. It Turns Out We Are Renting the Ground Beneath Them

The Infrastructure We Did Not Decide

Change Hub 2: Why organisations need change capability, not just change managers

Prepared as a downloadable companion to the AI gold rush series.